

The runes

The first forms of writing used by Norse and other Germanic people were angular carved marks called runes. Appearing around the 3rd century CE, runes stayed in use until the 16th or 17th century. They functioned like an alphabet, with 24 runes in the oldest form, the Elder Futhark, and 16 in the more recent Younger Futhark.

Each rune, however, was much more than just a letter; it was a symbol or pictogram. The word “rune” itself means “letter” and “mystery,” and runes were a secret language of power and magic. For example, the letter that correlates to T was Tiwaz, the sky god, and looked like an arrow pointing up to the sky. The arrow was not just a pointer—Tiwaz was a war god, too, and the rune was carved to ensure victory in battle. The letter that corresponds to U was Uruz, which stands for *auroch*, the name of the now-extinct giant cattle that roamed Europe, and it represented “strength of will.”

Some runic inscriptions were thought to be magic spells and were meant to be spoken with the *galdralag* (a specific poetic rhythm) to unleash their power. This spoken origin may be much older than the written form of runes. Legend has it that runes always existed and were discovered by the war god Odin as he underwent a terrible ordeal hanging from the world tree Yggdrasil. The runes were carved into the trunk by the three Norns, the female beings believed to control fate. Runes showed the Norns’ power to carve out the fate of all.

► **The Rök Stone** in Sweden, dating from the 9th century CE, bears the longest runic inscription in the world.

